

Nielsen's 10 Usability Heuristic Evaluation

System: Amazon

Workflow Evaluated: Product discovery → product evaluation → cart → checkout

Evidence: Five screenshots collected during the shopping workflow

Severity Scale

Rating	Meaning
0	No usability problem
1	Cosmetic/minor issue
2	Minor usability problem
3	Major usability problem
4	Usability catastrophe

Heuristic 1 — Visibility of System Status

Severity: 2 — Minor

Amazon generally provides good feedback about the user's current state. For example, the Search Results page clearly displays:

"1-16 of over 100,000 results for 'headphones'"

The Cart page also clearly displays the current subtotal and checkout button.

However, some important information is visually competing with promotional content. The Checkout screenshot contains delivery dates, Prime promotions, pricing, and multiple delivery options simultaneously. This can make it harder to immediately determine the current checkout state.

Evidence:

- Search Results screenshot
- Cart screenshot
- Checkout screenshot

Finding: System status is generally visible, but competing promotional information reduces the clarity of the primary task state.

Heuristic 2 — Match Between the System and the Real World

Severity: 2 — Minor

Amazon uses familiar shopping terminology such as:

- "Shopping Cart"
- "Price"
- "FREE Returns"
- "Delivery"
- "Add to cart"
- "Buy Now"

These terms generally match users' expectations.

However, Amazon's use of promotional terminology and Prime-specific options introduces additional complexity. For example, the Checkout page presents several delivery choices alongside a prominent Prime trial offer.

A user primarily trying to answer "When will my item arrive and how much will it cost?" must distinguish between normal delivery, Prime delivery, and promotional messaging.

Evidence: Checkout screenshot.

Finding: Amazon generally matches real-world shopping concepts, but commercial terminology and promotions can compete with the user's primary mental model of completing a purchase.

Heuristic 3 — User Control and Freedom

Severity: 2 — Minor

Amazon provides several controls for modifying a purchase. On the Cart page, users can:

- Change quantity
- Delete the item
- Save for later
- Compare with similar items
- Share the item

The Checkout page also allows users to select between multiple delivery options.

However, the large number of options and links means users may need to carefully determine which action will actually change their order versus which action leads to another feature or promotion.

Evidence: Cart and Checkout screenshots.

Finding: Users have substantial control, but the number of available actions increases the cognitive burden of choosing the correct one.

Heuristic 4 — Consistency and Standards

Severity: 2 — Minor

Amazon consistently uses recognizable shopping conventions, including:

- Yellow/orange primary action buttons
- Product images
- Prices
- Ratings
- Quantity controls
- Shopping cart terminology

However, the interface is visually inconsistent in how different sections are presented. The Starter Page uses large promotional cards, the Search Results page uses product cards, and the Product Page uses several different panels and information areas.

This isn't necessarily a functional error, but the visual density and variety of components make the overall experience feel less consistent.

Evidence: All five screenshots.

Finding: Individual components follow familiar conventions, but the overall interface contains many different visual patterns competing for attention.

Heuristic 5 — Error Prevention

Severity: 1 — Cosmetic/Minor

Amazon provides several mechanisms that help prevent purchasing mistakes.

For example, the Cart page clearly shows:

- Product name
- Product image
- Quantity
- Price
- Subtotal

The Checkout page also requires users to select a delivery option.

These features help users verify their purchase before proceeding.

However, the screenshots do not provide enough evidence to determine how effectively Amazon prevents more complex errors, such as accidentally purchasing the wrong variation or misunderstanding a subscription/Prime-related option.

Evidence: Cart and Checkout screenshots.

Finding: Basic purchase verification is strong, but additional testing would be required to evaluate error prevention throughout the complete transaction.

Heuristic 6 — Recognition Rather Than Recall

Severity: 3 — Major

This is one of the stronger issues in the screenshots.

The Search Results page contains a large amount of information simultaneously:

- Product images
- Product names
- Prices
- Ratings
- Review counts
- Sponsored labels
- Shipping information
- Filters
- Deals
- Promotional content

The Product Page similarly contains product information, specifications, purchasing options, Prime information, protection plans, shipping information, and advertisements.

Users must repeatedly scan and remember information when comparing products.

For example, the Product Page places the product specifications in the central area while purchase options are located separately in the right-side panel.

Evidence: Search Results and Product Page screenshots.

Finding: Amazon requires users to process and remember large amounts of information across different regions of the interface.

Severity: 3

Heuristic 7 — Flexibility and Efficiency of Use

Severity: 2 — Minor

Amazon provides many shortcuts and options for experienced users:

- Search
- Filters
- Sort
- Add to Cart
- Buy Now
- Saved items
- Prime delivery
- Product comparison

The Search Results page also provides numerous filters that can help experienced users narrow results.

However, the number of available options can make the interface more difficult for less experienced users. The filtering area alone contains numerous categories and choices.

Evidence: Search Results screenshot.

Finding: Amazon provides strong flexibility, but this flexibility comes with increased complexity.

Heuristic 8 — Aesthetic and Minimalist Design

Severity: 3 — Major

This is arguably the strongest heuristic problem visible in the screenshots.

Amazon's Starter Page contains numerous promotional panels, product sections, deals, advertisements, and navigation categories.

The Search Results page similarly combines:

- Sponsored products
- Regular results
- Filters
- Shopping ideas
- Deals
- Product information

- Ratings
- Shipping information

The Product Page contains an especially high amount of information within a single screen.

Although the information is useful, the quantity of competing information increases cognitive load.

Evidence: Starter Page, Search Results, and Product Page screenshots.

Finding: The interface prioritizes providing a large amount of commercial and product information over reducing visual and cognitive complexity.

Severity: 3

Heuristic 9 — Help Users Recognize, Diagnose, and Recover From Errors

Severity: 1 — Minor / Limited Evidence

The screenshots do not show an actual error state.

Therefore, there is insufficient evidence to identify a major violation of this heuristic.

Amazon does provide descriptive text around important actions, such as:

- "FREE Returns"
- Delivery dates
- Order pricing
- Quantity
- Product availability

These can help users recognize important purchasing information.

Finding: No significant error-recovery issue can be established from the provided screenshots. Additional testing would be needed using intentionally incorrect inputs or failed actions.

Severity: 1

Heuristic 10 — Help and Documentation

Severity: 2 — Minor

Amazon provides many links and informational elements, including:

- "Learn more"
- "See more"
- "More time slots available"
- Product details
- Returns information
- Shipping information

This demonstrates that help and additional information are available.

However, because so much information is displayed simultaneously, users may have difficulty determining which information is relevant to their immediate task.

For example, the Cart page contains promotional content in addition to purchase information.

Finding: Help and supporting information are available, but the amount of additional information can contribute to information overload.

Severity: 2

Heuristic Summary

#	Heuristic	Severity
1	Visibility of System Status	2
2	Match Between System and Real World	2
3	User Control and Freedom	2
4	Consistency and Standards	2
5	Error Prevention	1
6	Recognition Rather Than Recall	3
7	Flexibility and Efficiency	2
8	Aesthetic and Minimalist Design	3
9	Error Recovery	1
10	Help and Documentation	2

Highest-Priority Findings

The two most significant heuristic issues are:

1. Aesthetic and Minimalist Design — Severity 3

Amazon presents a very large amount of promotional, product, navigation, and purchasing information simultaneously.

2. Recognition Rather Than Recall — Severity 3

Users must scan and mentally process information distributed across different sections of the interface, particularly when evaluating products.